

Speech variation under information-theoretic constraints

- Different information-theoretic correlates are shown to predict different types of variation:
- More informative/unpredictable items maintain higher distinctiveness/are more resilient to variation.
- For example:
 - Frequencies correlate w/ word durations (Baker & Bradlow 2009) & vowel merger rates (Kang, Yoon & Han 2015).
 - Functional load (# of minimal pairs) correlates w/ merger rates & vowel lengths (Wedel et al. 2013).

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- How **generalizable** are these findings?
- Most previous studies:
 1. Focused on specific types of variation (duration, merger, lenition, etc.).
 2. Used acoustic data as an estimate of speech production behavior.

